

Library Column: 'Food for Fines' an opportunity to get rid of late charges



George Williams, Latah County Library District

A few years ago when I was working at Boise Public Library, a man came into the bookmobile and told me he was there to return some books and pay late fees for his father. I asked him who his father was and he named - well, let's just call him "Mr. P" to keep his privacy safe. I knew his father and asked if Mr. P was OK. He said his father was in the hospital and that he wasn't expected to live. Then he said, "When I walked into my father's room, the first thing he said to me was, 'You've got to get my books back to the bookmobile, they're a week late already!' "

People don't like library fines. Nobody really likes to pay them and most library employees don't like collecting them. Late fees are no fun. I always remember Mr. P, who died just a few weeks later, and that late library books were at the front of his mind on his deathbed. Of course I waived the fees on Mr. P's card and told his son not to worry about it and that, even if he'd just been sick at home instead of the hospital, I probably would've done the same. He had always been good about getting his books back on time. But I always think of this when people ask me why we have library fines in the first place.

The late fee policy involved research and discussion all the way up to the library's Board of Trustees, but for me the issue really comes down to fairness. Last year the Latah County Library District spent over \$120,000 on library materials - books and stuff - and almost all of that money came from taxes county residents paid to the library district. We have a responsibility to make sure that the materials we purchase are available to library users because everyone living in Latah County

helps pay for them. Most of our items check out for three weeks at a time because we've determined that this is a fair amount of time for a person to read or listen to a book. The purpose of late fees, then, is so that there are consequences to keeping materials for an unfair amount of time. Movies, of course, are the exception - they only check out for one week and the late fees are higher - but the principle is the same.

The bottom line is that for some people, a 10 cents per day fine is all that keeps them from holding on to the library's copy of "The Bridges of Madison County" for 20 days past its due date. And money seems to be the only consequence we can really use when people unfairly keep library books out of the hands of others who would like to use them. It's not like we can make someone take a time-out if they don't return something on time - the only consequence we can impose that really matters people is to charge late fees.

That being said, the Latah County Library District is doing its annual "Food For Fines" campaign again in just a few weeks. Between April 14 and 25, all seven branches of the Library District will accept donations of non-perishable food items in lieu of late fees owed to the Latah County Library at the rate of one item per dollar. So if you happen to have a \$2 fee on your account because it took you 11 days to watch the library's DVD of "The Great Muppet Caper," bring in a couple of cans of tomato soup and we will forgive your fine.

This is a win-win scenario for people who owe us money for late fees.

All of the food we collect will be given to local food banks and you'll have your fines forgiven. Once your account is cleared, you'll be able to start checking out library materials again.

It would be nice if every library user was as conscientious as Mr. P. If we never had late items, late fees wouldn't exist.

However, if you currently have some, here's an opportunity to clear them by emptying your pantry instead of your pocketbook.

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